

PERSONALIZING DEBATING:
DIVERSITY AND TOLERANCE IN THE DEBATE
COMMUNITY

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Frequently posts to eDebate (e.g., April 2004),¹ the electronic listserv for intercollegiate policy debate, have described a controversial phenomenon in debate, namely the use of personalized discourse to articulate a specific position of progressive social change in the debate community. More specifically, the discussion centered in April 2004 on the arguments advanced by University of Louisville debaters who have essentially claimed that rap, instead of "traditional" forms of evidence,² along with personal narratives should be used to support the position that the debate community is exclusionary against people of color. Their position continues to claim that they have made real advances to change the community, including their "project" of rejecting "traditional" forms of debate (privilege, evidence, flowing, styles of argument, etc.), recruiting marginalized student populations, providing scholarships to targeted high school groups, advancing a campaign of inclusion of different voices, etc. Such advances are difficult to counter since they are in large part unverifiable and do not justify by themselves the insertion of personalized arguments within the debate round. When opponents try to question their own privilege and advance ideas of changing the community, Louisville has responded with a series of arguments, including tokenism, insincerity, divide-and-conquer, and so on. The question then becomes, at what point should the personal intercede into the debate round? Are the

¹ These discussions can easily be referenced via the searchable archives of the eDebate listserv, at www.ndtceda.com.

² In another eDebate post, Ede Warner (2005), the coach of the University of Louisville, described how their project does not forbid "traditional" forms of evidence. Their project, nevertheless, privileges "non-traditional" types of evidence and criticizes "traditional" debate practices. In another post, Warner (2004b) goes so far as to indict traditional evidence as "crappy."

concerns and voices of individuals who feel slighted in the debate community appropriate for actual debate rounds? Should issues of racism, marginalization, sexism, and the like which occur in the debate community be subject to actual debates within the debate community, or should they be discussed in venues and forums that are more appropriate to discussing structural issues of the community? These questions, among others, have become highlighted in the discussions on eDebate.

The purpose of this essay is to outline what I strongly believe is a fundamental problem with recent debate techniques – the personalizing of debating. The intent is not to isolate or overly criticize the arguments advanced by the University of Louisville specifically, but rather to locate their arguments as a case study for how debate rounds have become highly personalized. Even before Louisville's project (and certainly Louisville is not the only team that currently engages in this type of debating), individuals and groups alike were personalizing debate arguments, making it difficult for opponents and judges to decipher, understand, analyze and come to grips with such arguments in a forum meant for hypothetical policy-making. In essence, the personalizing of debating has emerged wrought with frustrations, anxiety, resistance and backlash. To be sure, many have embraced the idea to gain a strategic edge in competitive debate rounds as well as to be self-reflexive of their own participation in an activity that probably does need restructuring. However, the central problem of this new phenomenon – the personalizing of debating – is twofold: it victimizes debate, and it ignores deeper, perhaps more important structural problems within the debate community.

There is no question that intercollegiate policy debate is at a crossroads. It suffers from a severe lack of diversity, in terms of female debaters as well as debaters of color. Stating the obvious, McRee and Cote declare that "twenty years of data have begun to cement an agreement among forensics educators that there exists a serious lack of diversity in debate" (2002, p. 29). This problem is especially acute when one looks at the teams clearing into elimination rounds and which debaters receive speaker awards at both regional and national tournaments. Very few would argue, I suspect, that diversity is not a problem.

In fact, the opposite is true (Bartenan, 1995, 1998; Bile, 1999; Bruschke & Johnson, 1994; Crenshaw, 1993a, 1993b; Hunt & Simerly, 1999; Loge, 1991; McRee & Cote, 2002; Rogers et al., 2003; Rowland, 1993; Sowards, 1999a, 1999b; Tuman, 1993; Wilkins & Hobbs, 1997; Williams, McGee & McGee, 1999; Zompetti, 1999). However, the real debate occurs as to the core causes of this problem and how to address them. In the past five years or so, some debaters and debate teams have introduced the diversity problem into actual debate rounds, arguing that "traditional" debate is exclusionary and problematic. Their arguments focus on several core issues: traditional debate excludes certain types of evidence (i.e., narratives, music, etc.), traditional debate privileges affluent individuals (i.e., the cost of summer institutes, travel budgets, etc.), traditional debate ignores the reality of many individuals who are already at a disadvantage in the activity (i.e., debaters of color and women). These teams then use these types of arguments, coupled with a patchwork of hip-hop music clips and personal testimony, along with soliloquies on how the current resolution precludes their perspectives. The result is a highly effective and advanced amalgamation of *ad hominem* attacks, fallacies of composition (the part represents the whole), guilt appeals and, to use Kenneth Burke's (1962) term, victimage. In essence, many debates on college campuses have become venues for complaints about how the current order of things (aka "status quo," or as Rogers et al. (2003) call it, the "ISM") in intercollegiate debate is occurring.

Before addressing specifically the issue of personalizing debate, I want to pause to address another, separate argument lodged by teams like Louisville. Such teams often critique "traditional" pedagogy for its reliance on banking, top-down forms of education. Stemming from the perspective of critical pedagogy (Freire, 1993), this critique argues that traditional pedagogy includes instruments of alienation which require personal attention to overcome the marginalization and oppressive conditions associated with traditional pedagogy. While I generally agree with the tenets of Freirian critical pedagogy, I am unconvinced that the personalized nature of debate falls within its purview. As a matter of fact, the dialogic nature of debate can actually foster the organic learning process of critical

pedagogy, absent personalizing it (Wade, 1998; Warner, 2001). Furthermore, as I will argue below, even if traditional debate practices have problems, personalizing debate within the specific debate round is not the most effective means for creating change. Finally, one can also dispute that personalizing debate is actually a *bone fide* element to critical pedagogy. Given the therapeutic nature of personalized debate, such argumentative transactions almost become like disputes on a playground where one debater essentially says "my daddy can beat up your daddy," or translated it becomes "my oppression is worse than your oppression." And, because these arguments occur in a debate round, they are articulated precisely in this way. As I will argue below, a much more effective strategy is to engage, in the spirit of critical pedagogy, in a community-based discussion of structural issues regarding privilege, as opposed to competitive, albeit strategic, arguments in specific debates.

Many, if not most, of the complaints heard in debate rounds have merit. As a community, we must address the issues of exclusivity, tolerance, respect and diversity. However, when debaters make arguments about these issues in debate rounds, the arguments become personalized, often seen as attacks against specific individuals, namely the "other" team (in arguments such as "you don't address your privilege," or "you don't do anything or aren't doing enough for diversity"). The so-called "Other" that debaters refer to as being marginalized becomes transferred onto "other" individuals and teams as the competitive structure of a debate necessitates. The point, then, is not that these complaints and concerns should not be discussed, but that they should not be discussed in actual debate rounds. I should also add that since diversity is still an on-going concern, we must question the efficacy of personalized debating at generally improving diversity in our community. Even if other solutions fall short as well, they at least avoid the pitfalls of personalized debating that I now begin to explore.

Interjecting the personalized into debate rounds has become highly problematic. As discussions on eDebate demonstrate¹ and my own discussions with folks who have judged

¹ See Arnett, 2004; Hoe, 2004; Parcher, 2004; Warner, 2002.

teams like Louisville¹ suggest, these arguments have increased anxiety, frustration, anger and resentment. To be fair, these arguments have also facilitated much soul-searching and self-reflexivity in the community. However, except for the Urban Debate League (UDL) movement² little, if anything, is being done to correct for inadequacies and inequities in the community, contrary to the appeal of the personalized arguments. In fact, any benefits from the personalization of debate can be accrued from enhancing other strategies: larger community discussions (as evidenced by some messages on eDebate),³ discussion fora at national tournaments,⁴ special high school debate institutes,⁵ clear directives and discussion during the CEDA and NDT business and roundtable meetings,⁶ more sensitive topic selection,⁷ etc. The drawbacks to personalizing debate, however, are, in my opinion, enormous. I will elaborate on two significant problems of engaging the personal in actual debate rounds: victimhood and therapy rhetoric.

The first major problem with this new form of debating is its appeal to victimage. Through victimage and scapegoating, a rhetor uses a purification ritual as a means of identifying and blaming the guilt onto an “appropriate” other. This commonality helps form identification among people when such blaming is in common (Burke, 1962, p. 22). In other words, victimage necessarily implies the understanding that one is in a position of marginalization. In debate, marginalized groups gain credit for being victims by arguing

¹ Multiple unscientific discussions have occurred with other judges regarding this style of debate. Those judges will remain anonymous since those discussions occurred prior to the undertaking of this manuscript.

² UDLs are referred to as movements by William Baker (1998), who discusses their exciting proliferation among various inner cities throughout the U.S. For more on the impact of UDLs on diversity in debate, see Breger, 1998; Crenshaw, 1998; Lee, 1998; Lynn, 1998; Mitchell, 1998; Snider, 1998; Wade, 1998; Warner & Bruschke, 2001; Ziegelmueller, 1998.

³ Many on eDebate have discussed how the listserv can be used as a form of empowerment. See McAfee, 2004; Sherwood, 2003; Turley, 2003.

⁴ For instance, the Wake Forest Shirley Classic has, on occasion, scheduled specific times for community discussions on several topics, including diversity.

⁵ See Shaw (2004) regarding the Women's high school debate institute, and Warner (2004a) concerning the Louisville summer high school debate institute.

⁶ See Turley, 2004.

⁷ See Hester's (2002) suggestion.

their plight among the community. There is no shame in that. However, many so-called "victims" deploy these arguments in actual debate rounds. I have no problem with discussions of exclusivity and underrepresentation in our community, but let me be clear: Such arguments should not be the focus of debate competition.

On one level, we clearly have a problem in our community, namely the marginalization of diverse groups. On the other level, we have arguments about problem "x" occurring in debate rounds where debate teams may not have access to knowledge concerning the problem of the community-at-large or they may not be prepared to debate such issues (after all, one is reminded of the importance of clash in individual debates). Clearly, we have a mismatch concerning a topic and its venue. The concomitant positions advanced by a team in favor of changing the community are essentially "debate-proof." We may initially want to congratulate such debaters for their strategic prowess: For how can one debate against the claim that one "feels" or "perceives" marginalization? Such claims are unverifiable and dependent on the person who is advancing the argument, not on the one answering it. In essence, then, victimage arguments "stack-the-deck" in favor of those advocating such positions.

One may also insert the role of the judge into this equation. Judging debates is hard enough, particularly when debaters already personalize judge's comments. After all, when debaters make arguments, they put forward part of themselves and are vulnerable to criticism. But for many years debaters have claimed that judges are too subjective in their assessments, particularly when forms of racism and sexism emerge, subtly or not so subtly, in some judge's comments. When debaters engage in a more explicit form of personalized debating, the role of the judge is even more difficult. In addition, any critical comment from a judge runs the risk of being misperceived. The result is a more frustrating and anxiety-prone activity precisely because the arguments become personalized, as opposed to placing them within the larger community context.¹

¹ Supra note 4.

My position, then, is not that such arguments are untrue (yes, marginalization exists), but rather that such claims are not debatable. Hence, no clash can occur when such arguments are made. This destroys the nature of debate because it not only nullifies any ground the other team may have, but it also sets a very dangerous precedent where some team personally argues "x" where no alternate team may respond with "y." This is dangerous, of course, because debate as we know it ceases to exist – the fundamental element of clash (i.e., the different affirmative and negative burdens) becomes moot and irrelevant. Victimhood, as is true with society as a whole, becomes the ultimate trump card where someone's personal feelings, beliefs, or journeys supercede any attempts at verifying or locating expert testimonial evidence to the contrary. What's more, an even more dangerous impulse occurs – that people in positions of power may appropriate the arguments and rhetoric of the marginalized for their own ends¹ (Dubber, 2002).

The second major problem with this turn in contemporary policy debate is its deflection, if not downright rejection, of more fundamental or core problems which are the cause of marginalization. Dana Cloud (1998) poignantly argues that when focusing on the personalizing of "debating," society stifles dissent, which is probably more important and powerful at ushering-in social change than particularized attention to therapeutic, albeit victimized, perspectives. The will to engage in discourse about transgression is one of individualized therapy, as if the individual's psychological condition is at stake (e.g., arguments about "discursive violence" are often deployed to this end). Her argument is primarily one about key progressive change – should we focus on individual notions of psychological distress or the larger group's problem of resource-based scarcity and exploitation? If one is compelled by the argument that we should look self-reflexively² and comprehensively at the nature of excluding debaters of color and other marginalized groups, then we might be tempted to agree with the outcome of piecemeal solutions and incoherent

¹ It is difficult to tell if anyone has yet appropriated marginalized discourse in debate rounds. However, since *personal* claims of oppression are largely unverifiable, such appropriation could be occurring without anyone noticing.

² An argument Warner (2001) claims himself, among others (See Woods, 2001).

policies. On the other hand, we may want to analyze how such relationships occurred and grew when other relationships and situations were not as obvious. In fact, we may want to even broaden our interpretation of such relationships – exactly how are students of color marginalized? Why do folks believe they have nothing to contribute? Why do students of color feel excluded?

It is very difficult, if not impossible, to get at these questions during a collegiate debate round. Not only is the limited time in a round an impediment at answering these complex questions, but both debaters of a single team may advance different personalized arguments, creating a moving target of advocacy that the opposing team and judges have difficulty in specifically pinning down for thorough and productive examination. Or, as Cloud suggests, such therapeutic arguments "deflect [sic] the energy and radicalism of activists," essentially creating a shell-game during private discussions of much larger societal problems (1998, p. 34). In addition, these questions are often skirted in debate rounds because there is a drive for competition. While some critical self-reflection has undoubtedly occurred as a result of personalizing debate, the overwhelming majority of debaters and coaches spend less time thinking about the core problems of marginalization (and their solutions) than they do locating debate strategies to beat personalization arguments at the next tournament. During squad meetings and coaching sessions, one does not hear an opposing team sincerely talk about their privilege or the exclusion of women or people of color in the debate community. Instead, one hears about what topicality argument, framework argument, or counter-narrative will be deployed to win the judge's ballot. The problem of therapeutic rhetoric underscores how personalized debating prevents examination of more important factors such as resource disparity.

Thus, the underlying therapeutic nature of personalized debate, coupled with the competitive component of trying to win debate rounds nullifies any chance at a fruitful and productive discussion about the problems of marginalization and their potential solutions. A focus on the personal – *my* experience, *my* narrative, *my* feelings, how *I* learn, how *I* can engage the community – is quite seductive; we all want to know how we fit into the larger

structure of the community. And, given the intense nature of our activity, it is easy to get lost in how our feelings of hard work, emotional attachment, anxiety, despair, excitement, success, and so on become interfaced with larger community trends.

Ultimately, however, a focus on the personal is a dead-end. The community's composition of multiple persons, who become focused on themselves, ignores the community at large. This can be seen with the move toward personalizing debating. Instead of examining problems of resource disparity (high costs of travel, scholarships, lack of novice tournaments, disparate coaching staffs, etc.) which plague debaters and debate programs throughout the country,¹ the personalization arguments focus on different styles of debating (slow vs. fast, hip-hop vs. traditional evidence), individual identity (black vs. white, privileged vs. marginalized), and praxis (I'm doing something about the problem vs. you're not). Indeed, as Cloud argues, the "privatizing, normalizing, and marginalizing discourses of the therapeutic are incompatible with a public-, policy-, and change-oriented definition of politics" (1998, p. 7).

There is no question that individualized and personalized questions of debate style are important to examine – some debaters learn better through different styles and some styles are more exciting than others. And, if those are the questions the community wants to ask and deal with, then so be it. However, if we are serious about creating a climate of tolerance, respect and diversity, then much deeper, structural (i.e., not personalized) issues must be addressed first. We would do well to note Rogers et al., who argue:

The forensic community has made significant progress over the past few years towards understanding the complexities of the differing presentational styles, argument forms and analysis of subdominant cultural groups hoping to bridge the gap between understanding, tolerance and both significant representation and participation in debate. None would argue against the goal of significant inclusiveness and its overall contribution to the pedagogy of a complete forensic

¹ For more on the structural and resource barriers to participation, see McRee & Cote, 2002 and Wade, 1998.

experience resulting in education. In spite of our efforts, the participation and success rates for women and minorities within intercollegiate, competitive debate remain disparagingly low (2003, p. 2).

As such, the problems of diversity and privilege in the debate community cannot be addressed in individual debate rounds, particularly through arguments about "non-traditional" evidence, argumentative style and cultural forms of learning. The highly personalized nature of such arguments creates feelings of victimhood. The competitive aspect of a debate round makes the therapeutic rhetoric of argumentative style displace the larger, structural impediments to a diverse and tolerant community. Again, if we refer to Cloud, we can translate her use of "private" for a "debate round," particularly if we juxtapose the *private* debate round to the community writ large:

. . . the therapeutic is a rhetoric that encourages a reformist rather than revolutionary political stance It is dangerous . . . to allow the therapeutic to set the bounds of our political imagination to the extent that it becomes difficult even to conceive of revolutionary change . . . the therapeutic asks activists to retreat from the public struggle for even modest reforms in favor of private wound-licking (1998, pp. 159-160).

And this is what personalizing debating does. While projects such as Louisville's declare ambitions of "community change" and radical social transformation, what they are really doing is keeping such arguments in the closet by performing their therapeutic rhetoric of victimhood in private debate rounds. If revolutionary change is the intent, then revolutionary action should occur to change the structural and institutional barriers to more diverse involvement and success in debate (Cloud, 1998, p. 166). Personalizing debating, as competitive arguments, in a private debate round does nothing except breed frustration, victimage, and displacement of more lofty efforts.

Debate should remain a simulated activity where students gather together to clash about issues of social controversy related to a resolution. During the simulation, debaters

learn to engage each other with civility, obtain vital skills,¹ and engage about a common societal problem, rather than personalized problems that may or may not be a reflection of larger community issues. If there are problems about who gets to participate, what topic gets debated, or what styles of debate get introduced, then those are issues the community as a whole needs to address, not the individual debaters.

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¹ For a discussion of the skills associated with debate, see Parcher (1998).

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